

is demonstrated by physical skills such as the movement of limbs, coordination, manipulation, dexterity, grace, strength, speed. Most children with autism have challenges in these skills at different levels.

Psychomotor skills deal with the actions using hands, fingers, wrist, etc. These skills have a great impact on the day to day life of children with autism. Improving these skills to a level so that they can manage their daily activities is a must for the better future of the child. Children with autism encounter objects that vary in shape and size daily. Unless they have good psychomotor skills, they face challenges in using those objects in their day to day lives. Normally, these skills are imparted and enhanced through training with special educator's help, who is trained in this.

## Conventional training

Conventional training of children with autism is done by special educators. Psychomotor skills are usually imparted by special educators (also called occupational therapists), and they are trained in educating children

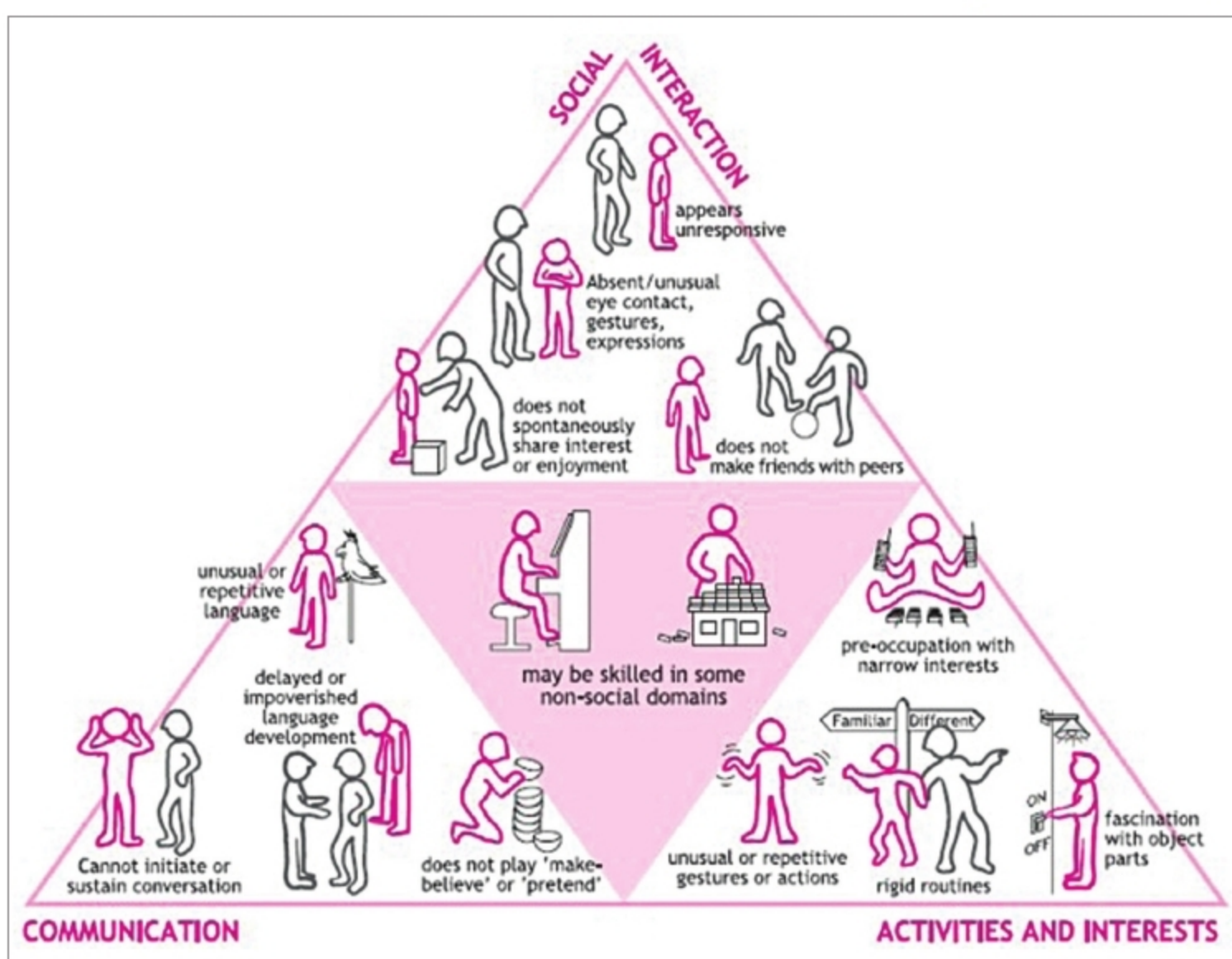


Fig. 1: Communication activities and interests (Credit: www.autismtopics.org)

with dedicated training tools. The best way to understand conventional training is explained in Fig. 2.

Conventional training of a child with autism involves a three-step process.

1. In the first step, the trainer demonstrates a child on how a particular activity, which involves a specific psychomotor skill, is done (violet dotted line and numbered as 1)

2. In the next step, the trainer holds the hand of the child and teaches him/her how to perform an activity

(red dotted line numbered as 2)

3. In the last step, the trainer makes the child perform an activity with or without verbal cues (blue dotted line numbered as 3)

The important point to note is the absence of feedback to the child for its actions. This leads to longer training duration and also relatively lesser retention of the skill learnt. It is also very important to note that the role of the trainer is more of a facilitator, and he is not directly responsible for the outcome of training. The challenges



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